

Maria Silva

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LLB and LLM graduate with practical experience in contract review, case file management, legal research, hearing preparation and client-facing advice, gained at BCLP, Citizens Advice East Berkshire, Q-Legal and Adobe. Experienced in managing matters from instruction through to submission, working across real estate disputes, international arbitration and general legal advisory work. Comfortable handling high volumes of documents, maintaining organised records and communicating clearly with clients and stakeholders. Currently advising clients on housing, benefits, employment and debt matters at Citizens Advice, with an LLM in Comparative and International Dispute Resolution in progress at Queen Mary University of London.

EDUCATION

Comparative and International Dispute Resolution LLM — Merit **Sept 2024 – Oct 2025**

Queen Mary University of London

- Modules covering international arbitration, dispute resolution, procedural law, legal research and evidence analysis
- Dissertation on data protection and the development of GDPR across jurisdictions
- Transnational Law and Governance Applied module (data privacy and democracy) — 75%

Law LLB — 2:1 **Sept 2020 – June 2024**

University College London

- Modules included Alternative Dispute Resolution, Advanced Contract Law, Commercial Law and Company Law

International Foundation Programme in Law and International Relations **Sept 2019 – June 2020**

King's College London

- Awarded the Leaders of Tomorrow prize (top 20 of a 200-student cohort; partial funding toward undergraduate degree)

EXPERIENCE

Citizens Advice East Berkshire · Maidenhead **July 2026 – Present**

Legal Adviser

- Advises clients across housing, welfare benefits, employment, family, debt and consumer matters; takes detailed factual statements and establishes chronologies
- Manages matters from first interview through to submission: drafts correspondence, prepares applications and document schedules, maintains confidential case records and meets deadlines
- Assesses eligibility against statutory and regulatory criteria; identifies evidential gaps and researches complex legal points
- Translates complex rules into clear, practical guidance for vulnerable clients

Bryan Cave Leighton Paisner LLP (BCLP) · London **Aug 2023 – Feb 2024**

Legal Placement Student — International Arbitration

- Supported a complex investment arbitration: reviewed and organised evidence for procedural submissions and the claimant's memorial; amended sections of the memorial and drafted procedural orders and procedural histories
- Became the only junior on the team shortly before a significant submission deadline, coordinating documents, tracking outstanding actions and helping ensure on-time delivery
- Maintained structured electronic case files and monitored procedural deadlines throughout the matter
- Liaised with the client on required documents; coordinated Romanian translations with an external translator

- Received feedback from a partner and associate that performance was comparable to a newly qualified solicitor

Bryan Cave Leighton Paisner LLP (BCLP) · London

Feb 2024 – Aug 2024

Legal Placement Student — Real Estate Disputes

- Prepared electronic hearing bundles and assisted with skeleton arguments and court materials
- Conducted legal and factual research on leasehold issues, rights of light, easements and landlord and tenant disputes
- Assisted with court filings, matter opening and closure, deadline tracking and cost comparisons
- Managed large volumes of confidential documents across several matters with competing deadlines; maintained matter records via iManage
- Prepared client notes and supported hearing arrangements

Q-Legal · London

Oct 2024 – Jan 2025

Legal Adviser

- Managed a data-privacy matter from client instruction through to formal written advice letter, under a qualified solicitor's supervision
- Researched UK GDPR and Data Protection Act 2018 obligations, including children's personal data and adtech, and identified compliance risks from the client's data processing
- Translated complex statutory requirements into clear, commercially focused advice; coordinated with client and supervising solicitor to meet deadline

Adobe · London

June 2022 – Aug 2022

Legal Intern

- Reviewed and amended software licensing agreements; identified contractual risks and assessed alignment with internal legal and compliance requirements
- Reviewed confidentiality and data-processing provisions; researched UK GDPR, EU GDPR and cross-border personal data transfer requirements
- Liaised with sales, legal and international business teams to resolve contractual queries and communicate amendments to stakeholders
- Prepared and delivered an internal presentation on breach-of-contract risks and mitigation measures

SKILLS

Languages: Portuguese (native), English (fluent), Spanish (basic)

Technical skills: Legal and commercial research; documentary analysis; concise report and correspondence drafting; Microsoft Word, Excel and PowerPoint; iManage; legal research databases; electronic court filing portals; document review; electronic bundling; case management and time-recording systems

Case and evidence management: Evidence review, hearing bundle preparation, procedural histories, case-file organisation, deadline tracking across multiple concurrent matters